



OVER 700 structures have been destroyed in Spokane, Wash., since the fires broke out Saturday afternoon.

EDISON TOWER SPARKED EATON FIRE

As utility battles suits, an official report finds its old infrastructure set off the blaze.

By GRACE TOOHEY

Out-of-service equipment managed by Southern California Edison started the deadly Eaton fire that killed 19 people and destroyed much of Altadena in January 2025, according to a long-awaited report by state and county fire officials.

The report, released Tuesday by the California Department of Forestry and Fire Protection and Los Angeles County Fire Department, confirms long-held suspicions about the fire's origin after it sparked near a utility tower the night of Jan. 7, 2025.

"After 18 months of thorough review of all evidence, alongside retained electrical and metallurgical experts, the investigation concluded that the cause of the wildfire conflagration was due to the electrical arcing events that took place on the out-of-service Southern California Edison tower," L.A. County Fire officials wrote in a statement announcing the report.

The report lists eight violations of state criminal and public utility codes, among others, that appear tied to Edison, but the details were redacted. The redactions are due to an ongoing review of the evidence by the L.A. County district attorney's office.

Edison officials have said for months that one of its century-old transmission lines likely caused the fire, but the utility, facing multiple lawsuits, has denied full responsibility for the fire, including financially, in court. It has, however, offered an opt-in payout program for fire victims.

In its annual report, company representatives told shareholders the utility acted as a "reasonable" operator before the fire, despite failing to upkeep its aging infrastructure. The Times has reported extensively on this Edison infrastructure where the fire started, including how the area was known as a potential fire hazard.

Dave Eisenhauer, a spokesperson for Edison, said the company is reviewing the report.

"We have taken our potential role in the start of this fire seriously from the beginning," Eisenhauer said. "Our hearts are with the Altadena community, and we continue to support them as they recover and rebuild through [See Edison, A8]

In similar conditions, armed with L.A. lessons

Three blazes threaten Spokane as firefighters arrive from Southern California to lend assistance

By CLARA HARTER AND RONG-GONG LIN II

Santa Monica Fire Department Deputy Chief Tom Clemo has barely slept since Saturday. He's spent the last three days based in a high school in Spokane, Wash., leading a command post of crews assigned to fires that have destroyed roughly 700 structures and have remarkable similarities to the destructive firestorm that hit Los Angeles County in 2025.

"What we have been witness to and are managing now is a wind-driven brush fire that resulted in an urban conflagration in neighborhoods similar to [those in the] Palisades and Eaton [fires]," Clemo said. "They're small in footprint but enormous in damage."

Both the Spokane and Los Angeles wildfires ignited while a "Particularly Dangerous Situation" was in place, the most extreme wildfire warning issued by the National Weather Service. It means that low humidity, powerful winds and high temperatures are creating the perfect conditions for wildfires to spread voraciously.

Whipped by fearsome winds and fueled by a tinderbox of dry vegetation, three wild-

fires ignited on the edge of the wildland-urban interface in eastern Washington.

California firefighters like Clemo have joined the fight, which could offer a grim preview of what is ahead for California amid dry conditions and rising temperatures due to climate change.

The scale of destruction seems to be one of "hundreds and hundreds of homes," Washington Gov. Bob Ferguson said.

With fires flanking Spokane to its north, east and west, Spokane Mayor Lisa Brown called the fires "the worst natural disaster our region has faced." The fires came as Spokane recorded its 10th-driest June on record, with just 0.26 of an inch of rain for the month — just 22% of normal, and as not a single drop of rain fell in July. The state of Washington has been in a statewide drought emergency since April 8 due to near-record-low snowpack.

UC climate scientist Daniel Swain called the trio of fires — now called the Spokane Area Fires — "the single most destructive fire in Washington state history."

The devastation comes as extreme weather conditions across the American West are becoming ripe for intense wildfires should an ignition occur. For now, [See Spokane, A8]

ARREST MADE: Suspect charged in Spokane's largest wildfire. **NATION, A4**



VIVIEN KILLILEA Getty Images for Robina Benson Design House

DIWALI honors the spiritual victory of light over darkness. Above, a celebration in West Hollywood.

State's Hindu holiday caught in court battle

Foes oppose religious preference for Diwali. Supporters say it's about communities.

By KAREN GARCIA

The celebration of Diwali involves lighting the way for the goddess of prosperity and abundance into your home. It's also a time to recognize the relationships in your life by celebrating with loved ones, sharing a meal or swapping gifts.

The holiday — also known as Deepavali and the Hindu "Festival of Lights" and celebrated by Hindus, Sikhs, Jains and Buddhists — was set to become California's 12th state-recognized holiday when Gov. Gavin Newsom signed legislation

to that effect last year.

But the new state holiday is in legal limbo after a local group filed a petition with the Sacramento County Superior Court, arguing that the law was too costly to implement, violated the U.S. Constitution and, more importantly, established Diwali as a preferred religious holiday in the state.

By officially adding Diwali to the statewide public holiday list, the law would have allowed some school staff and state employees who celebrate the holiday to get a new paid holiday.

It also would have given schools and community colleges the authority to close on the holiday, and allowed teachers to incorporate classroom exercises that acknowledge and celebrate it.

That was problematic for [See Diwali, A5]

Letters reveal threats behind Carvalho's exit

LAUSD board listed accusations against chief. His attorneys called them a 'hit job.'

By HOWARD BLUME

In a confidential letter that preceded the June resignation of Los Angeles Unified Supt. Alberto Carvalho, the school board accused its heralded leader of unprofessional conduct, unsatisfactory performance and "violation of or refusal to obey" state laws or school district regulations.

The June 8 letter, obtained by The Times in response to a public records request to the school district, signaled the board's intent to either fire Carvalho or force his resignation.

Over seven pages, the Board of Education provided its justifications for Carvalho's termination, citing allegedly unreported gifts, unreported outside in-

come and donor-funded travel. The accusations also included alleged unauthorized handling of district property and improper use of district resources, including a car and driver intended for work-related tasks.

In addition, Carvalho received "gifts from contractors and lobbyists beyond the limits permitted by law," the letter alleged.

Carvalho's attorneys responded to the letter eight days later with a detailed confidential letter of their own, also obtained by The Times in response to a public records request to the district. The attorneys said the accusations were "legally and factually deficient" and "a political hit job — an effort to remove a well-regarded public official who had the courage to stand between the [Trump] Administration's immigration enforcement apparatus and the schoolchildren of this city."

On Tuesday morning, Carvalho's attorneys pro-

[See LAUSD, A6]

Lawmakers target soaring fuel profits

California officials seek to crack down on 'absolutely obscene' gains amid Iran war.

By BLANCA BEGERT

Sky-high earnings for oil companies and California refiners in the second quarter are renewing calls from state legislators to crack down on industry profits.

Marathon Petroleum, the second-largest refiner in the state, reported \$5.1 billion in profit Tuesday, more than four times the same quarter last year, after fuel supplies tightened during the Iran war and prices for oil and gas soared.

From April through June,

Chevron, the biggest refiner and second-biggest oil producer in California, made \$12.1 billion in profit, five times the amount in the same quarter last year, and its highest earnings in at least six years. Refiners PBF Energy and Valero also reported windfalls, with the latter earning \$3.7 billion, another fivefold increase from the year before.

"These profits are absolutely obscene," said state Sen. Josh Becker (D-Menlo Park), who along with Sen. Benjamin Allen (D-Santa Monica) has introduced a bill to give the state attorney general the power to prosecute price gouging in wartime. "There's this notion that these companies can't run profitably in Cali-

[See Earnings, A10]

Nike insiders charged in theft plot

Sneaker resales are now multibillion-dollar industry

By LIBOR JANY

One day last fall, Roy Lee Harvey got into a Lyft in Phoenix and headed across town. He and the driver started chatting, and authorities say Harvey told the man about his work buying high-end Nike sneakers from shoe companies and reselling them for a healthy profit.

The Lyft driver thought it sounded like a good business opportunity, so the two men exchanged numbers and later met up at an apartment in nearby Scottsdale,

where, according to police investigators, Harvey showed him into a room strewn with different pairs of Nikes and their cardboard boxes.

The most coveted shoe models, which the company manufactures in limited runs, can fetch three or four times more than their retail value on the resale market. Reselling sneakers has become a multibillion-dollar global industry. Social media influencers generate hype through unboxing videos that draw millions of views.

Fashionistas known as

sneakerheads scramble to buy and trade the latest styles, paying a premium for the rarest pairs. Some treat them as investments, never wearing their purchases in order to keep them in mint condition. Like a sports car or a fine wine, they say, the value of shoes can increase as they get older.

Harvey's collection was so vast that the Lyft driver became suspicious, according to a police search warrant affidavit reviewed by The Times. After leaving the apartment, police said, the driver googled Harvey and

[See Sneakers, A7]

Blanche will face Senate vote next

Committee advances his nomination for attorney general while the panel's Democrats oppose. **NATION, A4**

Odd odyssey into film criticism

The Times' Amy Nicholson welcomes Emily Wilson to the rough seas of reviews. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Partly sunny.
L.A. Basin: 82/67. **B6**



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

HELP FOR BOYLE HEIGHTS

County board passes measures to help businesses and residents recover from warehouse fire, and the City Council addresses aid too. **CALIFORNIA, B1**